

Where Conservation Meets Innovation: Srinivasulu, IFS

In an era when environmental governance is often caught between urgency and complexity, Srinivasulu of the Indian Forest Service stands out as a rare administrator who has managed to marry science with sensitivity, technology with trust, and conservation with community participation. Over more than two decades in public service, his career has quietly redefined what modern environmental leadership in India can look like.

Trained first as a scientist, Srinivasulu's approach to conservation was shaped long before he entered the civil services. A Gold Medalist in Agriculture from the University of Agricultural Sciences, Dharwad, ranked among the top national performers in molecular biology, biotechnology, and agricultural research, he secured a top rank in the Indian Forest Service examination. That academic rigour became the backbone of his administrative philosophy—decisions guided by data, policies informed by evidence, and innovation grounded in ecological realities.

His field postings tested this philosophy. As the Field Director of the Kali Tiger Reserve, he moved beyond the traditional boundaries of wildlife protection, demonstrating that the real challenge lies not within the forest, but in the villages around it. He showed that conservation succeeds not when wildlife is protected from people, but when communities are empowered through green livelihoods. More than 500 families were brought into the mainstream, creating thousands of hectares of inviolate space within the tiger reserve.

By strengthening camera-trap-based tiger monitoring and

encouraging scientific field research, he enhanced conservation outcomes while also transforming the reserve into a globally recognised, visitor-friendly wildlife destination.

Conservation, in his view, was never an isolated exercise—it had to be experienced, understood, and supported by people.

Innovation became even more visible during his tenure as Member Secretary of the Karnataka State Pollution Control Board. At a time when environmental regulation was often criticised for opacity, Srinivasulu introduced a suite of digital tools that changed how regulators, industries, and citizens interacted. From mobile applications for pollution monitoring and real-time effluent vehicle tracking to COVID-19 biomedical waste



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monitoring platforms and e-governance dashboards, transparency and accountability became built into the system rather than imposed upon it.

Beyond administration and technology, Srinivasulu's impact extends into storytelling as a powerful tool for conservation. He conceptualised and produced the award-winning documentary *The Kali*, which helped shape public perception and even contributed to the renaming of the tiger reserve itself.

The same belief guided a simple yet effective innovation during the COVID-year Ganesh Chaturthi: replacing a rigid "No POP" directive with a joyful, eco-friendly "Turmeric Ganesha" campaign that travelled across homes and states, earning national attention and recognition, including a Guinness World Records acknowledgement.

The Karnataka State Environment Award 2016, the H.V. Muniswamy Gowda Environment Award 2023, and the Asia Book of Records 2022, among other national and international honours, mark key milestones. Yet colleagues note that his true achievement lies elsewhere: in his conviction that conservation cannot succeed unless livelihoods and local aspirations grow alongside ecological protection.

His work and writings, detailed at www.srinivasifs.com, reflect enduring commitment to public awareness and education.